STRENGTH IN ORGANISATION

In elections in the past decade, organisational muscle and discipline have been the BJP's strength. Organisation-building, therefore, has been a recurrent theme in Congress internal reports and AICC sessions. The MP unit seems to have woken up to this. Nath has created a new organisational unit—*mandalam*—a layer between the booth and district committees where he has appointed workers of his choice.

Booth Level Agents or BLAs, that last-man connection to voters and voter lists, which has been a game-changer for the BJP, were also appointed well in advance for most polling booths in MP. The BLA's role is critical this time. The Election Commission of India has allowed voting from home for the physically challenged and those aged 80 and above and the BLA is the only one authorised to help them cast their votes. An app has also been built to check duplication of names in voters' lists.

Nath has also set up 42 committees to cater to the needs of different socio-economic groups such as slum-dwellers, weavers, priests, mechanics and even doctors. Young voters are also a focus area. In the three states, there will be 5.4 million first-time voters this time around. CM Baghel is banking on the 13,000-odd Rajiv Yuva Mitan Clubs, a Chhattisgarh initiative to promote local culture and sports, for this. Recently, Rahul Gandhi attended a felicitation programme of the clubs.

The BJP, meanwhile, has activated its well-oiled *panna samitis* and *panna pramukhs* to reach out to the electorate. In MP itself, 1.9 million party workers are engaged in this outreach, fanning out across the 64,000-odd polling booths. Both parties have also hired cyber warriors to populate social media platforms with text and videos to mobilise opinion and influence public discourse.

CANDIDATE SELECTION

With most pre-poll surveys suggesting tight contests in all three states, neither party wants rebellion or sabotage by those denied tickets. To forestall the possibility, the BJP has given tickets to a number of veteran leaders who lost last time. "The BJP learnt a lesson in Karnataka that changing too many tickets leads to rebellion and infighting, which cost the party dear in the polls. In Chhattisgarh, the party has avoided doing that," says a BJP MLA in the state.

BOTH PARTIES ARE CAREFUL TO SEE THAT REBELS DO NOT QUEER THEIR PITCH. THEIR TROUBLE-SHOOTERS ARE WORKING EXTRA HOURS TO PLACATE DISSIDENTS

In MP, the BJP has denied tickets to only 27 of the 127 MLAs. More importantly, it has relaxed its own rules of not giving tickets to those over 75 or to more than one member of a family. Octogenarian Nagendra Singh has been fielded from Gurh while his namesake and fellow octogenarian has been given a ticket from Nagod.

The Congress high command, particularly Rahul Gandhi, wanted winnability—assessed on the basis of the various surveys the party conducted—as the criterion for candidate selection. But the state units were unwilling to follow this formula in letter and spirit and wanted some of the incumbents, especially those close to the top leaders in the state, to contest. Depending on the resistance from the state leadership, the central team has been distributing tickets in a manner that adheres to the survey findings as far as possible. In MP, the Congress has fielded 39 candidates who will be contesting for the first time, but in Rajasthan, of the 76 candidates announced, most are incumbent MLAs or their kin. In Chhattisgarh, 22 out of the 71 MLAs have been dropped.

Despite all the caution, both parties are seeing several rebellions. Party trouble-shooters are working extra hours to placate the dissidents. But, like in the past, rebels could well spell the difference between defeat and victory. In 2018, independent candidates, mostly rebels, won in 12 constituencies in Rajasthan.

What could also queer the pitch for the two national parties is the presence of caste-based parties like the Samajwadi Party, Bahujan Samaj Party and Gondwana Ganatantra Party (GGP). Despite being part of the INDIA bloc, the Congress, Aam Aadmi Party and SP have yet to arrive at a seat-sharing arrangement in any of the states. Snubbed by the Congress, which wanted to leave only six seats for the SP in MP, the Uttar Pradesh-based party has announced 33 candidates in MP. In 2018, the SP won one seat in MP and finished second in five seats in alliance with GGP.

The presence of other parties impacts Congress prospects more, since the BJP has more strongholds in the three states. In 56 assembly seats in MP, the BJP has not lost the past three elections; the Congress in just 10. Likewise, in Rajasthan, the BJP has not lost the previous three elections in 28 seats, the Congress in five. Only in Chhattisgarh does the Congress have a marginal advantage, where the party has retained nine seats in the past three polls to the BJP's six.

Not just strategy therefore, but historical performance, too, will weigh on the minds of the candidates and voters in the three states. The results on December 3 will certainly have big psychological implications for both the BJP and the Congress, as also the two major rivals—Modi and Rahul—as they head for the bigger battle in the summer of 2024. ■